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tant in light of China’s increasing influence in the region through its Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) and growing political tensions. “BIMSTEC’s importance for India’s neighbourhood policy is growing exponentially. India being the largest economy in this grouping, its leadership is critical to its success,” adds Sen.

But similarities apart, there are also significant differences between BIMSTEC and Saarc. Rumki Majumdar, Economist at Deloitte India, says, “BIMSTEC aims to have a broader geographical reach than Saarc, connecting South Asia with Southeast Asia, thus evolving into an interregional organisation fostering investments and trade relations. This initiative aligns with India’s ‘Act East’ policy.” The members have also made a concerted effort to steer clear of contentious issues and have adopted a pragmatic approach, prioritising economic and technical co-operation over politics. They have agreed on a charter, which came into force

on May 20, that allows them to partner with the UN and international organisations.

HURDLES AND TRIUMPHS

At the last summit in Colombo in March 2022, seven sectors of co-operation were delineated. These are trade, investment, and development, including the blue economy, led by Bangladesh; environment and climate change, including the mountain economy, led by Bhutan; security, including energy and disaster management, led by India; agriculture and food security, including livestock, led by Myanmar; people-to-people contact, led by Nepal; science, technology, and innovation, including health and human resource development, led by Sri Lanka; and connectivity, led by Thailand.

These broad sectors cover all the important dimensions of the developmental and security challenges that the region is facing. BIMSTEC Secretary General Pandey says, “An eminent persons group has been tasked with aligning BIMSTEC’s agenda for regional co-operation with the sustainable development goals. The report will enable BIMSTEC to reform and repurpose itself and engage in new areas.”

Additionally, BIMSTEC member states have adopted the Master Plan for Transport Connectivity. It’s a comprehensive 10-year strategy (2018-2028) and action plan, supported by the Asian Development Bank (ADB), for improving transport linkages. They are now considering ways to finance the plan. “An Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation has already been negotiated and approved by the BIMSTEC foreign ministers and is likely to be signed at the next summit. In order to facilitate road travel across the region, a motor vehicle agreement is being negotiated, and we are hopeful of making progress,” says Pandey.

The maritime transport agreement has the potential to significantly contribute to the economic development of the Bay of Bengal region, says Sen of EY. “However, its successful implementation will depend on the commitment of member states to fulfil their obligations and work together to overcome challenges,” he adds.

BIMSTEC also has immense potential for strengthening the blue economy. It can promote responsible fishing practices, foster maritime co-operation for security and safety at sea, and facilitate the development of ocean-based industries.

Vishnu P. Sudarsan, Partner at JSA Advocates & Solicitors, says there are opportunities aplenty in the region, one of them being offshore wind energy. “With offshore wind potential in the Bay of Bengal running into several hundred gigawatts, joint development projects underpinned by grid connectivity would allow for the deployment of efficient and large-scale wind farms,”